exactly when the missiles would become operational, which in Helms' view gave Kennedy three extra days (from 16 to 19 October).[22] The most authoritative study of Penkovsky's espionage concluded: 'During the Berlin crisis of 1961 and the Cuban missile crisis in 1962, Penkovsky was the spy who saved the world from nuclear war.'[23] Baroness Daphne Park, a former senior SIS officer, has written that Penkovsky 'averted war in Cuba'.[24]

Would Kennedy have launched a military attack on Cuba had he not understood the readiness state of the missiles? Certainly, his initial reaction on 16 October was to favour an air strike. Some senior officials believed the operational status of the missiles should determine when they had to be destroyed, seeming to think the readiness of the missiles was an indicator of Soviet intent. On 16 October, McNamara told his colleagues, 'it is extremely important that our talk and our discussion be founded on this premise: that any air strike will be planned to take place prior to the time they become operational. Because *if* they become operational *before* the air strike, I do not believe we can state we can knock them out before they can be launched.'[25]

In the film *Thirteen Days*, McNamara makes this point forcefully without comeback from his colleagues. In fact, the argument was immediately challenged by Dean Rusk, who questioned whether Moscow would retaliate with surviving missiles against the US, when to do so risked US retaliation against the USSR. Later US (and British) intelligence estimates concurred with Rusk's assessments. McNamara's logic may have accorded with that of Helms, but it played no role in subsequent US preparations for attacks on the missiles. Indeed, reflecting years later, McNamara was clear that his comments came on the first day of the crisis, 'but after we began to think about it, that restriction began to look irrelevant.'[26] He recalled: 'I don't think we put great weight on the date on which they might become operational. At least I didn't.'[27] He added, 'we put very little trust in CIA estimates of when the missiles would be operational.'[28]

The argument that Penkovsky's information was vital depends on counterfactuals about how JFK might have acted. The question of whether the President would have attacked and invaded had a diplomatic settlement